

Chapter 2 — Review of Literature

2.1 Overview of Relevant Review

Hybrid and blended learning

Hybrid learning, also called blended learning, combines digital learning with face-to-face learning. It can include online modules, recorded material, virtual meetings, classroom teaching, workshops, demonstrations, and supervised practice. The important point is that these activities should form one planned learning experience. Garrison and Kanuka (2004) describe blended learning as the thoughtful integration of online and face-to-face learning. Their definition makes a useful distinction. A course does not become blended simply because an organization adds an online module to an existing classroom programme. The digital and classroom elements should support one another.

This distinction is important for corporate training. An employee may complete an online module before attending a workshop, use the workshop to practise a procedure, and later receive a digital refresher or assessment. In that sequence, each stage has a different purpose. The online stage can introduce concepts and allow self-paced revision. The face-to-face stage can be used for discussion, feedback, role play, and problem-solving. A later digital activity can reinforce key ideas after employees return to work. If the stages are poorly linked, employees may repeat the same material or fail to see how it applies to their jobs.

Bonk and Graham (2006) discuss blended learning across educational and organizational settings. They show that the term covers more than one delivery pattern. Some programmes use a small online component to support classroom teaching. Others use online learning for most content and reserve face-to-face time for application. The appropriate balance depends on the learning objective, the employees' work situation, the available technology, and the need for practice or discussion. For a bank, basic information about products, rules, or systems may be suitable for digital delivery. Complex customer situations, risk decisions, and procedural practice may need direct interaction with a trainer.

Boelens, De Wever and Voet (2017) identify four recurring challenges in blended-learning design: flexibility, interaction, facilitation of the learning process, and the affective learning climate. These challenges are relevant to the present study. Employees need access to the online part of a programme at a workable time and place. They also need opportunities to ask questions and receive guidance. The trainer must help employees connect material across learning modes. Finally, employees need to feel comfortable participating and making mistakes during learning. These factors support the view that hybrid learning should be assessed as a matter of quality and integration, not only as the presence of digital content.

Han and Ellis (2020) developed the Perceptions of the Blended Learning Environment Questionnaire to measure how learners experience a blended environment. Their instrument separates general perceptions from particular aspects of the online component. This approach is useful because employees may value one part of a hybrid programme while finding another part difficult. For example, employees may appreciate the flexibility of online modules but still struggle with access, technology, or the connection between online and classroom material. The present study follows the same general idea by examining flexibility, access, interaction, technology, and integration within the Hybrid Learning construct.

Hybrid learning in workplace training

Blended learning has been studied more often in universities than in workplaces. This creates a problem when findings are applied directly to employees. Students and employees experience learning under different conditions. Students may have course grades and academic schedules as their main incentives. Employees may have workload pressure, customer responsibilities, career expectations, and immediate job requirements. A training design that works well for students may not work in the same way for employees.

Bin Mubayrik (2018) reviewed workplace blended-learning studies and found a relatively small body of research compared with the extensive higher-education literature. The review concluded that blended learning can support authentic, collaborative, and flexible workplace learning. It also showed that the evidence base for organizational settings remains limited. Ashraf et al. (2021), in an umbrella review of blended-learning research, reached a similar conclusion. Engagement, satisfaction, and self-regulation were frequently studied, but much of the available evidence came from student populations.

The workplace literature nevertheless provides useful examples. Lee (2010) studied a six-week blended leadership-development programme in a Korean corporate university. The study found that different parts of the programme served different purposes. Online activities helped employees prepare and activate prior knowledge, while face-to-face activities supported application and transfer. This finding is relevant because it shows that training should be designed as a sequence. It also supports the use of retention and workplace application as outcomes that extend beyond an employee's immediate reaction to a course.

Agarwal, Goyal, Kumar and Modi (2026) examined a hybrid employee-development programme in the Indian financial-services sector. The programme combined instructor-led sessions, self-paced e-learning, gamified simulations, on-the-job practice, and live projects. Employees who completed the intervention showed improvements in performance over time. The study demonstrates that a well-planned combination of learning activities can support employee development. At the same time, it does not separate the effect of each component. It therefore leaves open the question of how employees' engagement and other learning conditions contribute to training outcomes.

Mulaudzi (2021) provides another workplace-focused source. The study examined the use of blended teaching for workplace training in the South African transport sector. It used a structured questionnaire with employees and training personnel. The items addressed work relevance, business efficiency, time and travel savings, flexibility, motivation, and barriers to using blended learning. As a Master's dissertation, it is not peer-reviewed journal evidence. It is nevertheless useful for understanding the practical issues employees may face in corporate blended training and for informing the wording of workplace questionnaire items.

The Mulaudzi questionnaire is particularly relevant to the Hybrid Learning part of the present study. Its items show that employees can judge whether training fits their work, saves time, supports flexibility, and contributes to business efficiency. These are practical questions that employees can answer from their own experience. The present study does not copy the dissertation's questionnaire as a complete scale. Its items are adapted alongside published literature so that they fit banking employees and the six-construct model. The dissertation is therefore used as a workplace source for item ideas, while peer-reviewed studies provide the main theoretical and empirical support for the literature review.

Evidence on training effectiveness

Research on blended learning generally reports positive outcomes, but the findings do not show that a blended format is automatically better in every situation. Bernard, Borokhovski, Schmid, Tamim and Abrami (2014) synthesized 117 studies and found a small-to-medium positive effect for blended learning when compared with conventional instruction. A later review by Bernard et al. (2017) also reported a positive average effect, while noting that results varied across subjects and course designs. The quality of the learning design appears to matter more than the amount of online content used.

Some studies report outcomes that are broadly similar between blended and conventional learning when a moderate share of classroom time is replaced with online instruction. This does not mean that hybrid learning is ineffective. It means that delivery format alone is an incomplete explanation. The content, the design of activities, the trainer's role, the support available to learners, and the way employees use the material all influence the result.

Training effectiveness can also be measured in different ways. Wang (2003), for example, developed a learner-satisfaction measure that included usefulness, course quality, system quality, instructor quality, and service quality. Satisfaction is important, but it is not identical to learning or performance. An employee may enjoy a programme without retaining the content. An employee may also find a programme demanding but later use the learning successfully at work. The present study therefore treats Training Effectiveness, Knowledge Retention, and Job Performance as separate constructs.

Learner engagement and trainer competence

Learner engagement is central to the present study because it explains how a training experience may influence later outcomes. Engagement includes attention, effort, interest, and active participation. It is more than attendance. An employee can complete an online module or sit through a workshop without concentrating on the material. Employees are more likely to understand and apply learning when they participate actively and see the relevance of the content.

Saroj, Sahney and Sekar (2026) offer the closest workplace example for this relationship. Their study of 375 employees examined blended-learning acceptance, instructor competence, and metacognitive skills as predictors of learner engagement. It then examined employee agility as an outcome of engagement. The study found positive relationships between the three antecedents and engagement. It also found that engagement was related to employee agility, and that supervisor support strengthened this relationship. The study is important because it places instructor competence and learner engagement within a workplace blended-learning model.

The present study uses Saroj, Sahney and Sekar (2026) to support two parts of its model. First, it treats Trainer Competence as a condition that may influence Learner Engagement. Second, it treats Learner Engagement as a mechanism that may connect hybrid learning with later outcomes. The present study differs in its outcome sequence. It examines Training Effectiveness, Knowledge Retention, and Job Performance instead of employee agility. Metacognitive skill and supervisor support are not included as formal constructs because the present study uses a smaller, more focused model.

Ye, Kuang and Liu (2022) provide further support for the importance of learner perceptions in blended learning. Their study of teachers in a professional setting examined ICT self-efficacy and organizational support for blended learning. These variables predicted attitudes toward blended learning, which then predicted its use. The study does not measure learner engagement or training effectiveness. It is still relevant because it shows that confidence in technology and support from the organization can shape

how people respond to blended learning. The published measurement items in that study are also useful for adapting technology-related questions for the present research.

Yang (2023) reported a related sequence from organizational support through ICT self-efficacy and engagement to satisfaction. Hassan, Bashir and Arshad (2020) examined learning engagement among business-school respondents. Although these studies were not conducted in banking workplaces, they support the broader idea that engagement is an important link between learning conditions and learner outcomes.

Knowledge retention, transfer, and job performance

Knowledge retention refers to the ability to remember training content after the training event has ended. It is different from immediate learning. An employee may understand a topic during a session but forget important details before they need to use them. Retention is especially relevant in banking because employees may need to recall procedures, compliance rules, product information, or system steps after a training programme is complete.

Wakekar et al. (2026) measured knowledge retention six months after training among community health workers. Participants who received blended training had higher retention scores than participants in traditional or e-learning-only groups. The setting was healthcare rather than banking, and the study used an objective knowledge test. Even so, it shows why retention should be considered separately from immediate learning. In the present study, retention is measured through employees' self-reported ability to recall and explain training content after a reasonable period.

The movement from learning to job performance is usually described in the training-transfer literature. Baldwin and Ford (1988) identified trainee characteristics, training design, and the work environment as three key influences on transfer. Their framework explains why training results may differ across employees and organizations. Learning needs to be relevant, employees need to be ready to use it, and the workplace must allow them to apply it.

Blume, Ford, Baldwin and Huang (2010) confirmed through meta-analysis that the work environment and organizational climate remain important for training transfer. Fecteau, Dobbins, Russell, Ladd and Kudisch (1995) also found that organizational commitment and social support were related to pre-training motivation and perceived transfer. These studies show that retained knowledge does not automatically become improved performance. It must be applied in a work setting.

Job performance is measured in this study at the task-performance level. Williams and Anderson (1991) distinguish task performance from organizational citizenship behaviour. Koopmans et al. (2011, 2014) later developed the Individual Work Performance Questionnaire, which separates task performance, contextual performance, and counterproductive work behaviour. The present study concentrates on task performance because training is expected to influence the quality, accuracy, efficiency, and application of work-related knowledge.

Holton, Bates and Ruona (2000) developed the Learning Transfer System Inventory to measure factors that support or hinder transfer. The instrument includes motivational, organizational, and content-related factors. Yamnill and McLean (2005) later tested a similar structure in a Thai organizational setting. This provides some support for adapting established training concepts across national settings, while still recognizing that language and organizational context require careful attention.

Organizational and supervisor support

Organizational and supervisor support are relevant to hybrid learning, even though they are not formal constructs in the model used in this study. Eisenberger, Huntington, Hutchison and Sowa (1986) introduced the idea of perceived organizational support. The concept refers to employees' beliefs about whether the organization values their contribution and cares about their well-being. In training, support may include time to learn, access to technology, encouragement from managers, and opportunities to use new skills.

Ye, Kuang and Liu (2022) found that organizational support for blended learning was associated with a more positive attitude toward blended learning. Saroj, Sahney and Sekar (2026) found that supervisor support strengthened the relationship between engagement and employee agility. These findings suggest that support may affect how employees experience training and use learning at work.

Support is not included in the present six-construct model because the study is designed for a modest sample and needs to remain focused. Adding further variables would make the analysis harder to interpret. The exclusion does not mean that support is unimportant. It remains a useful area for future research and for practical recommendations after the findings have been reviewed.

Training effectiveness in Indian banking

Research on training effectiveness in Indian banking is limited. Jain and Jain (2015) examined training effectiveness across public, private, and foreign banks. Their measure included commitment to training, access, relevance, benefits, and satisfaction. They found no significant difference in overall training effectiveness across bank-ownership groups. The study is relevant because it confirms that training effectiveness is an established concern in Indian banking. It does not, however, examine hybrid learning or explain how training delivery affects employee engagement and later work outcomes.

The literature reviewed above supports the present study in three ways. It shows that blended learning can be useful when digital and face-to-face activities are properly integrated. It shows that learner engagement and trainer competence are relevant to the quality of a workplace learning experience. Finally, it shows that training outcomes can continue beyond the immediate session through retention, transfer, and work performance. These ideas provide the basis for the theoretical framework discussed next.

2.2 Theoretical Framework

The present study uses six related theoretical perspectives. They help explain why hybrid learning and trainer competence may influence engagement, why engagement may affect training effectiveness, and why training effectiveness may be linked with retention and job performance. The theories are not treated as separate models. Together, they provide a practical framework for examining employee learning in a hybrid corporate setting.

Training evaluation: Kirkpatrick and Holton

Kirkpatrick's (1994) four-level model is widely used to evaluate training. The first level is reaction: how participants respond to the training experience. The second level is learning: what knowledge, skills, or attitudes participants gain. The third level is behaviour: whether participants use the learning in their work. The fourth level is results: the wider effect of training on organizational outcomes.

Kirkpatrick's model is helpful because it shows that training should not be judged only by immediate satisfaction. Employees may respond positively to a programme but fail to apply its content. They may also learn a procedure but need time and opportunity before using it in their jobs. The present study uses this logic to keep Training Effectiveness, Knowledge Retention, and Job Performance separate. Training Effectiveness concerns the usefulness and immediate understanding of training. Knowledge Retention concerns whether employees continue to remember important content. Job Performance concerns whether employees perceive an improvement in their core work.

Holton (1996) criticized the use of Kirkpatrick's model as a complete explanation of training outcomes. He argued that the model identifies levels of evaluation but does not fully explain why learning leads, or fails to lead, to later behaviour and results. Holton emphasized factors such as ability, motivation, and the work environment. This criticism is useful for the present study because it supports the inclusion of Learner Engagement and Trainer Competence. The study does not assume that hybrid learning directly creates better performance. It examines engagement as a possible link between the training experience and later outcomes.

Learner engagement

Fredricks, Blumenfeld and Paris (2004) describe engagement as having behavioural, emotional, and cognitive parts. Behavioural engagement includes participation, effort, and persistence. Emotional engagement includes interest, enjoyment, and a sense of connection. Cognitive engagement includes the effort learners make to understand, organize, and use ideas. These parts can be seen in workplace training. An employee may attend a programme but avoid discussion. Another employee may participate actively, ask questions, and try to connect the material with daily work.

Schaufeli, Bakker and Salanova (2006) describe work engagement through vigour, dedication, and absorption. Their framework is useful because it treats engagement as active involvement rather than simple satisfaction. In the present study, Learner Engagement is measured through attention, effort, participation, and absorption during hybrid training. The construct is expected to influence Training Effectiveness because employees are more likely to understand and use training material when they engage actively with it.

The workplace model reported by Saroj, Sahney and Sekar (2026) supports this position. It shows that learner engagement can act as a link between training conditions and a work-related outcome. The present study applies this idea to a different outcome sequence. It examines whether engagement connects Hybrid Learning and Trainer Competence with Training Effectiveness.

Trainer competence is included because the trainer remains important in a hybrid programme. A trainer needs subject knowledge, but subject knowledge alone is not sufficient. The trainer must explain content clearly, use digital tools with confidence, organize activities, and encourage employees to participate. These responsibilities are especially important when learning takes place across online and classroom settings. Employees may need help moving from self-paced digital material to group discussion or practical application. Trainer Competence is therefore treated as an antecedent of Learner Engagement, not as a separate training outcome.

Technology acceptance and confidence in digital learning

The Technology Acceptance Model developed by Davis (1989) explains technology use through perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use. People are more likely to use a system when they

believe it is useful and manageable. In a hybrid-training programme, employees may be less willing to engage with online modules if they find the platform difficult to access or do not see its relevance to their work.

Compeau and Higgins (1995) extend this perspective through computer self-efficacy. Computer self-efficacy refers to a person's belief that they can use digital technology successfully. It is different from objective technical skill. An employee may be capable of using a platform but still feel uncertain or anxious about doing so without help. Confidence in using the digital part of training may affect whether employees complete online activities and how much attention they give to them.

These theories support the technology dimension of the Hybrid Learning construct. The present study asks whether employees can access and use the digital platform without frequent disruption and whether the online content helps them understand training topics. It does not treat technology confidence as a separate construct because the model would become unnecessarily complex for the available sample.

Self-determination theory and flexibility

Self-determination theory, developed by Ryan and Deci (2000), proposes that autonomy, competence, and relatedness support internal motivation. Autonomy refers to a sense of choice and control. Competence refers to feeling capable. Relatedness refers to feeling connected to others. These needs are relevant to hybrid learning because different delivery modes may support them in different ways.

Online learning can give employees more control over the time and pace of study. This can support autonomy, especially when employees need to balance learning with work responsibilities. A clear platform and manageable activities can support competence. Classroom discussion, trainer feedback, and interaction with colleagues can support relatedness. Hybrid learning can therefore create a learning environment that supports several psychological needs at once.

Motivation is not measured as a separate construct in this study. Self-determination theory is used to explain why flexibility and interaction may influence engagement. Employees are more likely to invest effort in training when they have a reasonable degree of control, feel able to complete the work, and can obtain support from trainers and colleagues.

Blended-learning design

Garrison and Kanuka (2004) provide the central design principle for this study: digital and face-to-face learning should be integrated. Integration means that the two modes have clear and connected roles. Online learning may prepare employees for classroom practice. Classroom activities may build on online material. Follow-up digital resources may reinforce what was practised in person.

Boelens, De Wever and Voet (2017) help explain how this principle can be applied. Their four design challenges are flexibility, interaction, facilitation, and the learning climate. The Hybrid Learning items used in this study reflect these ideas. They ask about access to online material, opportunities for interaction, the use of digital tools, and the connection between online and classroom sessions. The study expects better integration to be associated with higher engagement.

Training transfer and job performance

Training-transfer theory explains how learning moves from a training event into workplace practice. Baldwin and Ford (1988) argue that transfer depends on trainee characteristics, training design, and the

work environment. A useful programme may still fail if employees cannot practise the new skill, do not receive support, or are unable to recall what they learned.

Blume et al. (2010) confirm that work conditions and climate influence transfer. This supports a careful interpretation of the final part of the present model. Knowledge Retention is expected to be associated with Job Performance, but the relationship may not be equally strong for every employee. Factors outside the model, such as workload, managerial support, and job opportunity, may affect whether retained learning is applied.

The present study therefore treats Job Performance as a downstream outcome. It does not claim that training alone determines performance. It examines whether employees who report stronger retention also report better task-related performance after training.

The link between retention and performance should be interpreted carefully. Employees may remember training content but lack the opportunity to apply it immediately. They may also face workload pressure, system constraints, or approval requirements that prevent a new practice from being used. For this reason, the present model tests whether retention and job performance are related in the selected setting. It does not claim that the relationship proves that training caused every later change in performance.

The conceptual model

The theoretical perspectives discussed above support the following model. Hybrid Learning and Trainer Competence are treated as antecedents of Learner Engagement. Hybrid Learning includes the quality of digital access, interaction, technology use, flexibility, and integration with classroom learning. Trainer Competence includes subject knowledge, effective use of training tools, and encouragement of employee participation.

Learner Engagement is expected to influence Training Effectiveness because attentive and active employees are more likely to understand and use the material. Training Effectiveness is expected to influence Knowledge Retention because relevant and understandable learning is more likely to be remembered. Knowledge Retention is expected to influence Job Performance because employees must retain training content before they can apply it in their work. The model does not include organizational or supervisor support as a separate variable. These factors are recognized as contextual influences and are discussed as limits and future research directions.

2.3 Case Study

Union Bank of India is used as the organizational context for this study. It is a large public-sector bank with a wide domestic branch network and a workforce of approximately 74,000 employees (Union Bank of India, n.d.-a). The size and geographic spread of the bank make employee learning a practical challenge. Training must reach employees in different locations while maintaining common standards for products, systems, compliance, and customer service.

The bank has a formal learning infrastructure. The Union Bank Knowledge Centre at Bannerghatta, Bengaluru, provides residential and classroom-based staff training. The bank also has training facilities in different regions. In addition, Union Vidya provides a mobile platform through which employees can access learning material, scenarios, quizzes, and progress tracking (Union Vidya, n.d.). The bank's

learning-management-system procurement activity also indicates continuing investment in digital learning (Union Bank of India, n.d.-b).

This combination of classroom facilities and digital resources makes Union Bank of India a suitable case for examining hybrid learning. The study is situated at the bank's Regional Office Chennai South, located at 38 and 39 Whites Road, Express Estate, Royapettah, Chennai, Tamil Nadu 600014. The case study does not claim that every employee receives the same programme or uses the same digital tools in the same way. It identifies the organizational setting in which employees experience a mix of digital and face-to-face learning. The empirical part of the dissertation will examine the views of employees who have participated in such training.

The case is also relevant because Union Bank of India has experienced organizational and technological change. The 2020 amalgamation with Andhra Bank and Corporation Bank increased the need for common processes and employee development. Digital banking has also increased the importance of current system knowledge and consistent service practices. These conditions make the effectiveness of employee learning an important organizational concern.

2.4 Gaps in the Study

The literature identifies four gaps that guide the present research.

The first is an explanatory gap. Many studies report a relationship between blended learning and positive outcomes. Fewer studies test the process through which the relationship occurs. Ashraf et al. (2021) show that engagement, satisfaction, and self-regulation are often reported as learning outcomes. They are less often tested as mechanisms that explain later training outcomes. Saroj, Sahney and Sekar (2026) provide a useful exception by treating learner engagement as a mediator in workplace blended learning. The present study builds on this idea by examining Learner Engagement as a link between Hybrid Learning and Trainer Competence, on one side, and Training Effectiveness on the other.

The second is a population gap. A large share of blended-learning research is based on students. Workplace learning differs because employees face job demands, organizational rules, and immediate application requirements. Bin Mubayrik (2018) shows that workplace blended-learning research is much smaller than the higher-education literature. The present study addresses this gap by examining employees of Union Bank of India who have experience of blended training.

The third is a sectoral and geographical gap. Research on training effectiveness exists in Indian banking, but there is limited research on hybrid learning within Indian public-sector banks. Jain and Jain (2015) examined training effectiveness in Indian banks without examining hybrid learning. The literature reviewed for this dissertation did not identify a verified study of the present six-construct model in Union Bank of India. The study therefore provides evidence from a large Indian public-sector bank.

The fourth is an outcome-chain gap. Existing studies usually examine one or two parts of the learning process. Saroj, Sahney and Sekar (2026) examine engagement and employee agility. Wakekar et al. (2026) measure later knowledge retention. Lee (2010) examines transfer into workplace practice. These studies are useful, but none of them tests the full sequence used in the present study: Hybrid Learning and Trainer Competence, Learner Engagement, Training Effectiveness, Knowledge Retention, and Job Performance. The present study brings these relationships together in one focused model.

The study does not claim that the model captures every influence on training outcomes. Organizational support, supervisor support, motivation, workload, and opportunity to apply learning may also affect the results. These factors are not included as measured constructs because the study uses a modest sample and needs a model that can be analysed clearly. Their role should be considered when the findings are interpreted and when recommendations for future research are developed.

The research is intended to contribute in two ways. It adds evidence on workplace blended learning in an Indian public-sector bank. It also examines a linked sequence from the hybrid-learning experience to engagement, training effectiveness, retention, and job performance. The findings can help clarify which features of hybrid training employees associate with useful learning and workplace application.